

Chapter 4: Tribals, Dikus and The Vision of a Golden Age

1. Introduction & Birsa Munda

- **Birsa Munda:** Born in the mid-1870s into the Munda tribe of Chota Nagpur (Jharkhand). People believed he had miraculous healing powers and could multiply crops.
- He declared himself a messenger of God sent to save his people from exploitation.
- **Dikus:** The term used for outsiders—such as money lenders, traders, missionaries, and British officials—who were seen as the cause of the tribals' misery.

2. How Did Tribal Groups Live? Tribal livelihoods were divided into four main types:

- **Jhum (Shifting) Cultivators:** Practiced shifting cultivation on small forest patches. They cut tree tops for sunlight, burnt vegetation for potash (a natural fertilizer), and shifted to new lands after harvesting.
- **Hunters and Gatherers:** Relied entirely on the forest for survival by hunting animals and gathering produce. They extracted oil from Sal and Mahua seeds for cooking. (e.g., The Baigas saw themselves strictly as people of the forest).
- **Animal Herders:** Pastoralists who moved with their herds (cattle, sheep, goats) according to seasons. (e.g., Bakarwals of Kashmir).
- **Settled Cultivators:** Settled in one place instead of moving. Land belonged to the clan as a whole. The British viewed settled tribes as more "civilized" than the shifting cultivators.

3. Impact of Colonial Rule on Tribals

- **Tribal Chiefs:** Before British rule, chiefs enjoyed economic and administrative power. Under colonial rule, they lost administrative powers and were forced to act merely as middlemen for the British.
- **Shifting Cultivators:** The British restricted shifting cultivation because settled peasants were easier to administer and provided steady revenue. After facing massive protests, they eventually allowed Jhum cultivation in some small forest patches.
- **Forest Laws & Impact:** Forests were declared state property. Some were classified as 'Reserved Forests' (for timber). Tribals were banned from hunting or gathering there, resulting in a severe loss of livelihood.
- **Problem with Trade:** Traders and moneylenders exploited the tribals. For instance, in Hazaribagh, traders bought silk cocoons for just ₹3–₹4 per thousand and sold them for five times the price elsewhere, plunging the tribals into deep debt.
- **Search for Work:** Many tribals were forced to migrate for work under harsh conditions and low wages, ending up in the tea plantations of Assam or the coal mines of Jharkhand.

4. Rebellions and The Birsa Movement

- **Tribal Revolts:** Driven by restrictions and heavy exploitation, tribals often rebelled (e.g., the Santhal Rebellion in 1855 and the Forest Satyagraha in 1930).
- **The Birsa Movement:** Birsa urged his followers to fight for their glorious past (the "Golden Age"). His goal was to drive out all "Dikus" and establish a **Munda Raj**.
- **Timeline:** He was arrested by the British in 1895 and released in 1897. He died of cholera in 1900, which caused the movement to fade out. However, it successfully proved that tribal communities had the capacity to protest and fight against colonial injustice.